

waged their own battles from the stands by unfurling tifos and taking digs at each other. While Bagan's fans exuded confidence in their demeanour, loyalists of the Red and Gold Brigade hoped for a twist.

However, the script did not deliver a surprise. Bagan triumphed over its arch-rival by a 2-0 scoreline, leaving East Bengal without a single point from its first five outings.

Prabhsukhan Gill spared the blushes for the home team with a couple of excellent saves but eventually crumbled under the pressure exerted by Australians Jamie Maclaren and Dimitrios Petratos, who scored in the first and second halves, respectively, to seal the win for the Mariners, the better team on the night.

East Bengal's new head coach Oscar Bruzon, who stayed in the dugout despite arriving in the wee hours of Derby Day, said his immediate priority is to get the team in shape and set realistic goals for the rest of the season.

Aneesh Dey

Goa looking for a turnaround

Beaches, music, booze, and football — Goa has it all. Football has long been a staple among Goans, though in recent times, interest in the sport has been waning. Dempo SC, Churchill Brothers and Salgaocar SC, once powerhouses in Indian football, have been pushed to the wayside.

The ISL gave birth to FC Goa, which has done all the right things and strived hard to fly the flag high for football in the state.

In the glitzy inaugural marquee season of 2014, FC Goa's lowest attendance was close to 16,000 at the Jawaharlal Nehru Stadium. However, in 2024, despite having established itself as one of the premier football clubs in the country, it is struggling to pull in the same numbers, even for its highest recorded attendance.

Match-going fans are a crucial part of any sports team, capable of uplifting its players. "Since coronavirus, not many people come for matches here," explains Trevor,

a retired policeman, sitting on a cement slab next to a tea shop facing the stadium.

Before the pandemic, Goa averaged between 16,000 and 17,000 spectators during the Sergio Lobera years from 2017 to 2020.

Lobera's Goa was the team to watch: free-flowing, breakneck-speed football, with Ahmed Jahouh and Hugo Boumous pulling off the unthinkable, and Ferran Corominas scoring for fun.

But even that didn't intrigue Trevor, though. "I have never watched a football game. I am a cricket fan. If they play cricket, I will go and watch," he chuckles. The closed-door matches during the pandemic from 2020 to 2022 hurt not just Goa but other ISL clubs too.

But Goa's failures on the pitch have also played a part. When the goals and points dried up, the gate receipts dwindled as well.

When the experienced Manolo Márquez arrived in 2023, there was renewed hope. But things have not improved this season. With five points from as many games, this is Goa's worst start to a campaign since 2016.

For its part, the club slashed ticket prices for the much-anticipated clash against Mumbai City FC. The lowest ticket price was set at ₹49, nearly five times less than the original price.

This comes as the club has announced it cannot afford the

stadium's rental fee. Earlier last week, FC Goa CEO Ravi Puskar disclosed that the club had to shell out a whopping INR 45 lakh to host a game and sought assistance from the government.

"We may have to shift to smaller venues because we may not be able to afford it anymore. If the ground and operating charges come down, which can happen if we have the support of the entire support system, we can make the ground accessible to everyone. It is not our intention to price out the fans," said Puskar.

Yet, on a sultry late-evening clash — a respite from the incessant monsoon showers in the region — the club managed a season-high attendance of only 11,824.

"For me, it's the team that has to show some things...then the crowd will come to the stadium. I feel this team will soon be a very competitive one," Márquez promised before the game.

But on the pitch, there weren't many moments that elicited cheers from the stands. It was the handful of Mumbai City faithful who had the last laugh as Goa lost its second home game of the season.

Aashin Prasad

Desperate times: Despite being one of the premier football clubs in the country, FC Goa is struggling to attract a solid attendance for its matches. FSDL

